

Beyond the door, the features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. This chamber is filled with heaps of yellow and silver blocks, as well as scale-like flat squares that shine in the light of glowing white sticks. Barrel-shaped white objects hold more blocks, transparent and shining in blue, green, and violet. Blocky caricatures of weapons, shields, armor, and helmets hang against the walls or are stacked in heaps. A pixelated haze hangs in the air, emanating from glowing cubes in a blocky red brazier.

Unpixelated. The room is filled with piles of coins, urns holding colorful gleaming gems, strange armor, and weapons. Smoke pours from red coals in a squat brazier in the form of a devil's head, which appears to be carved from a single red gem. Numerous white candles fill the room with light.

Poor Welcome. Any unfortunate thieves exploring the treasury must immediately contend with the fact that the entire room is filled with poison gas from the incense in the devilish brazier. Any creature that starts its turn in the room must succeed on a DC 18 Constitution saving throw or take 21 (6d6) poison damage and become poisoned until it leaves the room. A creature that holds its breath gets no benefit against the poison. If the door to area 6.28 is left open, the poison gas dissipates after 10 minutes.

Once the property of a great lord of Acheron, the treasury contains ancient riches from dozens of forgotten empires. The heaps of coins total 35,000 gp, 120,000 sp, and 42,000 cp. Several marble urns are completely filled with gems—mostly star sapphires, rubies, emeralds, and blue spinels—totaling 170 pounds and 108,000 gp in value. (A character who spends an action to scoop up a handful from any urn gathers gems worth $1d4 \times 1,000$ gp.) The devil brazier is carved from a single gigantic piece of rose quartz. It weighs 500 pounds and is worth 15,000 gp.

The finely decorated arms and armor include *+1 chain mail*, *chain mail of resistance (necrotic)*, *scale mail mariner's armor*, *+1 plate mail*, a *sentinel shield*, a *vicious longsword*, a *+2 longsword*, a *+2 spear*, a *greatsword of vengeance*, a *horn of Valhalla (bronze)*, and a *helm of teleportation*. These magic items are scattered among many nonmagical items of the same kind, and are easily spotted when the mundane items are seen in their pixelated state.

Each of the ten white candles in the room has a *continual flame* spell cast upon it.

AREA 6.27: LADDER SHAFT

A 20-foot-wide shaft with ladders on all four sides runs some 200 feet between the middle and lower levels beneath face 6. When Cube 1717 was fully functional, magic in the shaft allowed freight and important individuals to levitate up and down, but that magic has failed.

Two pixelated **veterans** stand beside the ladders, guarding this shaft from potential intruders. If they see any nonpixelated creatures climbing up from below

or in area 6.28, they telepathically alert the guards in area 6.19.

AREA 6.28: CONTROL ROOM

The beating of the Archquadrone's heart can be heard in the corridors leading up to this chamber, and is loud within.

The pixelating curse is stronger here than in the rest of the cube. While in area 6.28, creatures must make all checks and saving throws related to the curse every 10 minutes, rather than at the end of each short rest. The appearance of this chamber also cannot be unpixelated, even with Styx water, *pixel glasses*, or other magic.

This vast square chamber lies at the exact center of the cube. Pipes, valves, and gears cover the riveted iron walls here, occasionally moving, pumping, or hissing as they release strange-smelling steam. Red lights glow from red bricks on the wall. The room is totally pixelated and has no curved surfaces.

The skeletal remains of the Archquadrone fill the center of the room. They resemble little more than a 60-foot-wide dilapidated square framework of what looks like rotting sheet metal, and which shows only hints of the Archquadrone's face and empty eye sockets. Clearly visible through the vast rents in the Archquadrone's remains is the 10-foot-wide Heart Engine, which pumps at the center of the floor. The engine is perched over a wide pit that is bridged by pipes thick enough to walk upon. The pipes go everywhere, disappearing into the walls and floor.

A short flight of metal steps leads 10 feet above the Heart Engine to a metal platform. Two pieces of bulbous machinery squat there, with a large glowing cube floating between them. On the other side of the platform is a large panel of buttons, switches, and levers. A strange piece of furniture at the center of the platform resembles six chairs in a circle sitting back to back, with a crown of piping above them. This is the Six-Face Throne.

The Archquadrone's Remains. Little is left of the Archquadrone except for its heart and the shell of its skull. A character who saw the statue in area 6.12 recognizes it as the same creature. The remains can be confirmed as belonging to an enormously large and limbless quadrone with a successful DC 18 Intelligence (Arcana) check.

The Archquadrone's body can be damaged by any attack, but it's already dead. The Heart Engine must be attacked directly. However, a creature that touches any part of the remains and uses *detect thoughts*, *speak with dead*, telepathy, or a similar effect receives fragmentary images of the life of the Archquadrone and its desire to reshape the universe in its own image.

Heart Engine. This huge, crystalline cluster of square valves and pixelated pipes continually pulses and moves, and radiates palpable heat and a red glow. Black metal pipes ranging in size from 2 feet to 5 feet across emerge from the Heart Engine to enter the Six-Face Throne and the walls all around it. The engine is encircled by what appears to be a ring of shining gray-black metal, which also pulses in time with the beating of the heart.



PIXELATED STEEL PREDATOR

The Heart Engine is the nexus of the pixelating curse. Any creature that touches it with its bare flesh suffers the pixelating curse at an accelerated rate thereafter. That creature rolls to avoid infection, goes up another physical level, and rolls to avoid increasing their mental level of the curse every minute.

If the Heart Engine is destroyed, the pixelating curse is immediately dispelled and all the other parts of the cube become nonfunctional. The Heart Engine has AC 18; 180 hit points; immunity to poison damage; immunity to bludgeoning, piercing, or slashing damage from nonmagical attacks not made with adamantite weapons; and resistance to cold and fire damage. When damaged, it spills black pixelated blood, and all pixelated creatures and creatures attuned to the Six-Face Throne that are on or in the cube understand that the Heart Engine is in danger.

Predatory Defender. The ring of shining gray-black metal is actually the foremost defender of the Heart Engine: a pixelated **steel predator**^M with these changes:

- Its alignment is lawful neutral.
- It has telepathy out to a range of 120 feet, but can use it to communicate only with other pixelated creatures.
- It is immune to the frightened condition.

- It has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide while in a pixelated area.

The pixelated steel predator's mission is to guard area 6.28. If any creature threatens or attacks the Heart Engine, the Six-Face Throne, or any of the other controls in this area, it uncurls its panther-like body from around the heart and attacks until it or its foes are destroyed. It will even attack the skull lord and other creatures attuned to the Six-Face Throne if they attempt to damage it or the Heart Engine for some reason. The steel predator does not leave area 6.28 under any circumstances.

Going Down. Below and around the heart is a pit partially filled with the pipe-like 'guts' of the Archquadrone, and which slopes down into the slippery shape beneath it. A creature that enters this tight, red-lit space can crawl down into area 6.47, the exhaust shaft of the cube. However, this route is slippery with oil, and a creature must succeed on a DC 15 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) check to hold on as they climb. On a failed check, the creature slides out of control down toward area 6.47, and must succeed on a DC 16 Dexterity saving throw to grab onto the edge of the pit with their hands. On a failed save, the creature falls 300 feet down to the foul waters of area 1.1, taking 20d6 bludgeoning damage.

The Six-Face Throne. Resembling six throne-like chairs in a hexagonal shape stacked back to back, these six linked seats sit at the center of what used to be the Archquadrone's skull. Sitting just above the chairs is a crown-like nest of pixelated pipes and wires. If any creature climbs the steps to the Six-Face Throne unaccompanied by the skull lord, the pixelated steel predator uncoils itself from the Heart Engine and attacks.

The Six-Face Throne has AC 18; 90 hit points; immunity to poison damage; bludgeoning, piercing, or slashing damage from nonmagical attacks not made with adamantite weapons; and resistance to cold and fire damage. Even if the throne is destroyed, creatures attuned to it remain so attuned as long as the Heart Engine survives, and can continue to control the cube. However, no new creatures can attune to the throne and gain control over the cube until the throne is rebuilt by the skull lord over a week's time.

Created by Vargo, the Six-Face Throne allows up to six creatures to take control of the cube systems once controlled by the dead Archquadrone. A number of pixelated suction cups hang down from the tangle above on heavy wires, each just the right size to be attached to a humanoid head.

If a creature presses the suction cup against its head, what happens next depends on its Intelligence. A creature with an Intelligence of 14 or higher automatically becomes attuned to the Six-Face Throne (see below), after which the suction cup detaches. A creature with an Intelligence of 10 to 13 is unable to interface with the throne, and instead takes 7 (2d6) psychic damage. A creature with an Intelligence of

9 or less literally hurts the throne with its stupidity, triggering an explosion that deals 21 (6d6) psychic damage and 21 (6d6) thunder damage to that creature and each other creature within a 30-foot radius. Any creature aside from the triggering creature can attempt a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw, reducing the damage by half on a success. Any pixelated creature that takes damage from this explosion are stunned for 1d3 rounds.

Attuning to the Six-Face Throne. A creature that becomes attuned to the Six-Face Throne gains access to various powers, which it understands instinctively:

- It can communicate by telepathy with other attuned creatures at any range.
- It can use the gravity controls (see below) while in area 6.28.
- It can use the scrying mosaics (see below) if it is anywhere within the cube.
- It can use the cannon controls (see below) while in area 6.28 if five or more faces of the cube have been activated.
- All pixelated creatures obey its commands, unless those orders contradict with the creatures' desire to protect the Six-Face Throne and the Heart Engine. If different attuned creatures give conflicting orders to a pixelated creature, that creature obeys whichever order is in the majority. If there is no majority, the pixelated creature takes no action, unable to decide.

It's impossible to become attuned more than once to the throne. If an attuned creature tries to do so again, it takes 14 (4d6) psychic damage.

Between the skull lord's two intelligent heads and Sladek the pixelated mage, there are three creatures attuned to the cube when the characters begin the adventure. If one or more characters attune themselves to the Six-Face Throne while Sladek and the skull lord are alive, the Heart Engine starts to beat stronger and faster, and the cube's powers increase. See the "Awakening the Cube" sidebar.

Gravity Controls. The glowing cube that levitates on the platform near the Six-Face Throne is covered with symbols. Pixelated lightning shoots back and forth between the bulbous machines, surrounding the floating cube with a halo of crackling red energy.

The gravity control cube can be touched and manipulated easily by any creature attuned to the Six-Face Throne. Any other creature that tries to touch it must make a DC 18 Strength saving throw. On a failed save, the creature takes 28 (8d6) lightning damage and is unable to touch the cube that round. On a success, the creature takes 14 (4d6) lightning damage but can touch the cube.

Each face of the control cube is numbered from 1 to 6, corresponding to one of the six faces of Cube 1717. The face of the cube that is up corresponds to the face that is up and above the water on the Material Plane. As an action, a creature can gently turn the control cube in midair so that a different face is up. This causes a great rumbling and hissing of steam in this area that lasts for 1 minute while the cube 'rolls' outside, but that movement goes unnoticed inside.

AWAKENING THE CUBE

Vargo's ultimate goal is to awaken the full functionality of Cube 1717. The cube's powers are dependent on the number of active faces of the Six-Face Throne. Each effect is cumulative if one or more faces are active.

No Faces Active. All the interior lights in the cube go out. The only places with light are the forges in areas 6.16 and 6.18, and wherever fitful fires burst forth from broken pipes from time to time. The cube stops producing its own internal gravity and the local gravity of each of the faces, so that all areas conform to the prevailing gravity of the world outside. The pixelating curse stops spreading, although all currently pixelated creatures and areas remain pixelated as long as the Heart Engine survives. The damaged soul tap (area 6.14) stops producing its endless flow of bodies. The cube sinks to the bottom of the Sea of Swords, and the forge fires eventually go out.

One Face. Lighting and local gravity functions in the cube. The soul tap produces bodies as noted in the adventure.

Two Faces. The cube gains partial vertical propulsive power, allowing it to rise to the surface of the water for up to 4 hours each day.

Three Faces. As at the start of the adventure, the cube has increased vertical propulsive power, allowing it to stay at the surface of the water. It can also sink underwater if the controllers of the Six-Face Throne want it to.

Four Faces. The cube gains the ability to move vertically up or down at a rate of 60 feet per round. If Vargo is in control of the cube, the skull lord causes it to rise out of the water, allowing the *handkerchief of darkness* to be grabbed and ending the fog. Freed from the Styx sea, all the faces of the cube rapidly pixelate.

Five Faces. The cube's main cannon (extending from area 6.28A to area 5.5) powers up. A creature that is attuned to and sitting in the Six-Face Throne can use the controls to fire the cannon as an action. Doing so has the effect of a *meteor swarm* spell that can be aimed at any points within 1 mile of the exterior of the cube. Additionally, all creatures and objects caught in the area of the cannon's four fiery orbs automatically contract the pixelating curse. Each time the cannon is fired, all creatures attuned to the Six-Face Throne suffer one level of exhaustion.

Six Faces. The cube gains horizontal as well as vertical movement ability, flying at a rate of 60 feet per round. At this point, it is free to go anywhere in Faerûn.

The gravity control cube has AC 17; 30 hit points; and immunity to cold, fire, poison, lightning, and necrotic damage. If the control cube is destroyed, Cube 1717 stops producing its own internal gravity and the local gravity of each of the faces, so that all areas conform to the prevailing gravity of the world outside. The cube also stops moving and rolling, forcing creatures to exit it through the face that is currently above the water. A new control cube self-generates in one day.

Scrying Mosaics. Along each of the walls of this chamber at a height of 10 feet, as well as on the ceiling directly above the Six-Face Throne, a 20-foot-wide rectangular mosaic appears to show flat, square stones of gray, white, and black. Occasionally, the color of the stones changes, with white becoming black and vice versa in random patterns.